TGPSC GROUP 1 MAINS

Paper II · Unit I · Topic 5

Freedom Struggle, Mass Movements and Partition, 1885–1947

Expanded teaching draft — not yet fully verified or approved

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Syllabus and Index

Three Phases of Indian Freedom Struggle, 1885-1947. The rise and growth of All India Kisan Sabha, Workers and Tribal movements; Issue of Gender and Women’s movement; Growth of Socialist and Communist Movements; Growth of Communalism; Independence and Partition of India.

Mapping

- Three phases of freedom struggle: detailed notes sections 1–4

- All India Kisan Sabha; workers and tribal movements: section 5

- Gender and women’s movements: section 6

- Socialist and communist movements: section 7

- Communalism: section 8

- Independence and Partition: section 9

Amendment verification and paper-level syllabus audit remain pending.

Quick Revision

Three-phase framework

- 1885–1905: early Congress, petitions, representative institutions, civil rights and drain theory. The Congress first met in December 1885 under W. C. Bonnerjee.

- 1905–1919: Bengal partition protests, Swadeshi, boycott, assertive nationalism, revolutionary networks, Home Rule and Lucknow Pact. The periodization is a teaching aid, not a hard boundary.

- 1919–1947: Rowlatt protests; Non-Cooperation (1920–22); Civil Disobedience (from 1930); Quit India (1942); wartime politics, negotiated transfer and Partition (1947).

Precision dates

- 1905: partition of Bengal and launch of Swadeshi mobilization.

- 1907: Surat split.

- 1916: Home Rule activism and Congress–League Lucknow Pact.

- 13 April 1919: Jallianwala Bagh massacre.

- 1920: AITUC founded; Non-Cooperation launched.

- February 1922: suspension after Chauri Chaura.

- December 1929: Purna Swaraj resolution at Lahore.

- March–April 1930: Dandi march and salt satyagraha.

- 1934: Congress Socialist Party established.

- 1935: Government of India Act.

- 1936: All India Kisan Sabha established.

- 8 August 1942: Quit India resolution endorsed in Bombay.

- 1946: Cabinet Mission and naval ratings' revolt.

- 1947: independence, Partition and mass displacement.

Comparison cues

- Non-Cooperation withdraws collaboration; Civil Disobedience publicly breaches selected unjust laws.
- Political independence differs from agrarian reform, labor rights and annihilation of caste.
- National unity did not remove debate over minority representation and provincial autonomy.
- Hyderabad State was a princely state, not a British province; Telangana peasant struggle extends beyond 1947.

Exam traps

- Do not say Quit India immediately expelled Britain; it was suppressed but was politically consequential.
- Do not equate Muslim religious identity with support for the Muslim League.
- Do not describe Partition violence as confined to a single region or social group.
- Distinguish original practice questions from authenticated TGPSC PYQs.

Detailed Notes

1. Reading the national movement historically

A freedom struggle with multiple political languages

Between 1885 and 1947, the demand for Indian self-rule changed from demands for greater participation in imperial institutions to an insistence on sovereign independence. This transformation was neither automatic nor universally shared. Constitutionalists, revolutionaries, peasants, industrial workers, women activists, anti-caste organizers, socialists and communal organizations framed freedom in different ways. A sound analytical account asks who participated, what they wanted, how they organized and whose interests were incompletely represented. The Congress was pivotal but never exhausted the political life of colonial India.

The three phases: a teaching device rather than rigid boundaries

The conventional periodization is early nationalist or moderate politics, approximately 1885–1905; assertive or extremist-nationalist and Swadeshi activity, approximately 1905–1919; and mass Gandhian nationalism, approximately 1919–1947. Its strength is that it maps changing methods, from petitions and economic critique to boycott and coordinated civil resistance. Its weakness is the temptation to portray each phase as replacing the last. Constitutional negotiation, revolutionary violence, social reform and labor organizing persisted across these boundaries. The final phase itself included strategic changes, divisions and temporary suspensions.

Why war and world politics mattered

The First World War enlarged fiscal extraction, generated price pressures and created expectations of constitutional concession. The Russian Revolution inspired new debates about capitalism, labor and social justice. The Great Depression affected commodity prices and agrarian indebtedness. The Second World War intensified economic distress, brought Indian politics into a global anti-fascist and anti-imperial setting, and undermined British capacity to sustain rule. These pressures interacted with indigenous organization; neither world events alone nor one leader alone explain independence.

2. Phase I: Early nationalism, 1885–1905

Founding and social base of the Indian National Congress

The Indian National Congress first met in Bombay in December 1885, with W. C. Bonnerjee presiding. Its early membership was disproportionately English-educated and urban, including lawyers, professionals and journalists. Its sessions helped leaders from different presidencies and regions identify common grievances and coordinate political language. The social base was narrow, but newspapers, local associations and campaigns gave some demands a larger audience. It is inaccurate

to dismiss this period as politically useless merely because its repertoire appears cautious to later generations.

Moderate techniques and achievements

Early nationalists sought representative institutions, Indianization of higher services, budget transparency, administrative accountability, civil liberties and reduction of military expenditure. They used resolutions, delegations, public meetings and economic studies. The Indian Councils Act of 1892 offered limited enlargement of councils but not responsible government. Political concessions were restricted; nevertheless, the campaign normalized scrutiny of colonial finance and helped connect provincial issues to a larger Indian public sphere.

The economic critique of empire

Dadabhai Naoroji developed the drain-of-wealth argument: taxes, remittances, pensions, profits and payments abroad could transfer Indian-generated resources without equivalent domestic reinvestment. R. C. Dutt and others linked revenue systems and agrarian distress to colonial economic policy. The critique was not a single econometric formula, and historians debate the magnitude of different transfers. Its political consequence was profound: poverty became a question of institutions and power rather than simply individual backwardness.

Limits and internal critiques

Early Congress politics often assumed that argument and imperial liberalism could deliver reform. Elite dominance and limited participation by women, laborers and oppressed-caste communities narrowed its claims to represent the whole country. Still, petitions and councils should be evaluated as political choices shaped by surveillance, repression and resources, not as evidence that early leaders lacked commitment. Later mass movements inherited some of their organizational infrastructure and economic vocabulary.

3. Phase II: Swadeshi, assertive nationalism and new strategies, 1905–1919

The partition of Bengal and Swadeshi

Lord Curzon announced the partition of Bengal in 1905, officially on administrative grounds; critics argued that it also had divisive political consequences. Protests promoted swadeshi goods, boycotts of imported products, national education and public mobilization. Women, students, traders and sections of rural society participated, although their motivations differed. Swadeshi blended economic self-reliance with political protest. The 1911 reversal of Bengal partition was symbolically important, but it cannot be attributed to protest alone without considering changing imperial calculations.

Assertive politics and the Surat split

Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal and Lala Lajpat Rai emphasized assertive forms of agitation, self-reliance and swaraj. The Congress split at Surat in 1907 amid disagreements over leadership and methods; the contrast between Moderates and Extremists is useful but oversimplifies overlap in goals and mutual influence. Repression, prosecutions and factional divisions constrained the movement. The relationship between religion-inflected symbols and inclusive nationalism also requires scrutiny, because symbols that mobilize one constituency may alienate another.

Revolutionary nationalism

Groups and networks in Bengal, Maharashtra and abroad adopted clandestine organization, arms acquisition and targeted attacks. Their activities expressed frustration with the pace of constitutional politics and state repression. They drew on sacrifice and anti-colonial internationalism, but small clandestine cells faced severe intelligence and logistical challenges. Revolutionary nationalism should not be collapsed into the Congress program, nor treated as the dominant participation mode of the period.

Home Rule and the Lucknow Pact

The Home Rule Leagues associated with Tilak and Annie Besant in 1916 pressed for self-government and broadened public campaigning. The Congress and Muslim League reached the Lucknow Pact in 1916, indicating a moment of constitutional cooperation while accepting separate electorates and communal representation. This duality matters: political agreements

could foster joint negotiation while institutionalizing group distinctions. Montagu's 1917 declaration promised progressive realization of responsible government, but without immediate sovereignty.

War, coercion and the threshold of mass politics

War taxation, recruitment and price increases strained colonial society. The Rowlatt legislation of 1919 enabled extraordinary coercive powers despite Indian opposition. The massacre at Jallianwala Bagh on 13 April 1919 profoundly damaged imperial legitimacy. These events helped redirect anger toward mass politics, although local variations in mobilization remained substantial.

4. Phase III: Gandhian mass movements, 1919–1947

Gandhi's methods: satyagraha as political organization

Gandhi's campaigns at Champaran (1917), Ahmedabad (1918) and Kheda (1918) connected local grievances to a method emphasizing public discipline, nonviolent resistance and negotiation. Satyagraha was not mere passivity: it sought to make unjust authority difficult to sustain while keeping participants accountable for their conduct. Its success depended on organizing, resources, communication and the responses of authorities. Gandhi's national leadership also faced critics who rejected his social philosophy or his tactical decisions.

Khilafat and Non-Cooperation, 1920–22

The Non-Cooperation Movement linked anger over Punjab repression and colonial constitutional failures with the Khilafat issue. Congress adopted the campaign in 1920, encouraging boycott of titles, schools, courts and imported goods, together with spinning and national institutions. Its meaning varied: plantation workers sought mobility, peasants resisted landlords and forest communities demanded local rights. Gandhi suspended the movement after the violent Chauri Chaura incident in February 1922. The withdrawal sparked debate between nonviolent discipline and the risk of demobilizing an energized society.

Interlude, institutions and constitutional disagreement

After 1922, political activity diversified. The Swaraj Party, formed in 1923 by C. R. Das and Motilal Nehru, pursued council entry to obstruct colonial governance from within, while others stressed constructive programs outside councils. The Simon Commission, appointed in 1927 without Indian members, met widespread protest. The Nehru Report of 1928 proposed a constitutional framework but exposed disagreements over minority safeguards. At Lahore in December 1929, Congress declared Purna Swaraj as its goal and observed Independence Day on 26 January 1930.

Salt march and Civil Disobedience

Gandhi's Dandi March in March–April 1930 challenged the salt monopoly through a symbol intelligible across class and region. Civil disobedience embraced salt-making, refusal of some taxes, boycotts and demonstrations. Participation varied: business groups feared prolonged disorder; rich peasants and poorer cultivators could disagree over tax and rent demands; Dalit leaders developed independent political claims. The Gandhi–Irwin Pact in 1931 and Round Table Conferences showed interaction between protest and negotiation, not a simple straight line to concession. Renewed repression and shifting organization reduced momentum later.

Constitutional restructuring and provincial politics

The Government of India Act 1935 envisaged a federation that did not take effect and established provincial autonomy under continuing colonial constraints. Congress ministries took office in several provinces after the 1937 elections, giving nationalists governing experience but also exposing tensions over representation, reform priorities and relations with the Muslim League. Provincial office was not equivalent to independent national government.

Quit India and wartime rupture

The British decision to involve India in the Second World War without Indian consent intensified the dispute over sovereignty. After the failure of the Cripps Mission, Congress adopted Quit India on 8 August 1942. Top leaders were rapidly arrested; local activists, students, workers and peasants sustained decentralized resistance, including some sabotage and parallel

administrative experiments. Colonial repression was severe. The movement did not achieve immediate withdrawal, but the upheaval exposed the political cost of continued imperial rule.

INA, military dissent and the final political crisis

Subhas Chandra Bose led the Indian National Army, seeking independence through an alliance with Axis powers in wartime. The INA's battlefield campaign failed, and the political reception of its trials later energized anti-colonial sentiment. The Royal Indian Navy ratings' revolt of 1946 demonstrated unrest within imperial military structures, though its causes and leadership differed from Congress mass movements. Neither INA trials nor naval revolt single-handedly caused Britain's withdrawal; they belonged to a larger crisis of legitimacy, finance, war exhaustion and competing mass political claims.

5. Peasants, workers and tribal political agency

All India Kisan Sabha and agrarian demands

The All India Kisan Sabha was established in 1936, with Swami Sahajanand Saraswati as its first president. Local peasant organizations demanded rent reduction, debt relief, security of tenure, limits on landlord power and rights over cultivated land. Their politics intersected with Congress and left organizations but retained distinct agrarian priorities. The Bihar peasant movement, Awadh mobilizations and later Telangana peasant struggle should be compared without assuming identical land-tenure systems or chronologies.

The Telangana peasant struggle: careful chronology

In the Hyderabad State, agrarian inequality, vetti (forms of forced labor), landlord domination and princely authoritarianism provided conditions for communist-led peasant mobilization. The armed Telangana struggle developed primarily in the later 1940s and continued beyond Indian independence into the early 1950s. It cannot be attributed only to British provincial policy because Hyderabad State was a princely polity. For this particular syllabus topic, it illustrates how the wider anti-colonial period also involved struggles over land, caste and social power that independence alone did not resolve.

Industrial workers and trade unions

The All India Trade Union Congress was founded in 1920. Labor movements addressed wages, working hours, safety, recognition and colonial labor law. Workers joined nationalist protests in some settings while also acting through industrial disputes independently of Congress strategy. Differences among moderate unionists, communists and other socialists sometimes divided trade union organization. A strike was not automatically anti-colonial, and nationalists did not universally agree about labor militancy.

Tribal movements, forests and freedom

Adivasi resistance cannot be reduced to participation in Congress organizations. Forest laws, customary access, landlord and moneylender relations and missionary change shaped region-specific politics. Alluri Sitarama Raju's Rampa rebellion of 1922–24 in the Andhra hills drew on grievances about forest restrictions and forced labor and adopted guerrilla methods. Other tribal communities interpreted swaraj through their own land and livelihood concerns. The history of the freedom struggle must record those aims rather than treating tribal activists as supporting characters in an urban nationalist story.

6. Gender and women in the freedom struggle

Forms of participation and leadership

Women participated in picketing, salt protest, underground communication, demonstrations, relief networks, education, journalism and political organizations. Sarojini Naidu, Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, Aruna Asaf Ali, Usha Mehta and Sucheta Kriplani exemplify different modes of public leadership, but attention to famous figures should not erase anonymous participants. Household and caste obligations constrained mobility, even as mass campaigns created new space for political engagement.

Women's organizations and substantive demands

The All India Women's Conference, established in 1927, advocated women's education and legal-social reform, later engaging broader questions of rights and political status. Women's activists debated franchise, marriage, inheritance, labor conditions and representation. The category women was never socially uniform: caste, religion, class and location shaped experiences of nationalist politics. Participation in a movement for national freedom did not guarantee equal power within the movement.

Gender and the limits of nationalist rhetoric

Nationalist imagery sometimes treated women as symbols of moral purity or the nation-as-mother while political organizations remained male-dominated. Women's activism challenged this separation between symbolic importance and decision-making authority. In writing answers, distinguish women as icons in political culture, as organizers in campaigns and as thinkers demanding enforceable rights; these are overlapping but different historical roles.

7. Socialists, communists and ideological contest

Socialism within the nationalist movement

From the 1920s onward, socialist arguments gained ground in response to global revolution, depression, unequal landownership and labor organization. Jawaharlal Nehru and Subhas Chandra Bose emphasized economic planning and industrial development, though their political paths differed. The Congress Socialist Party was established in 1934 by leaders including Jayaprakash Narayan and Acharya Narendra Deva. Socialists often collaborated with Congress while criticizing its limits on agrarian and class issues.

Communist organization and political strategy

The Communist Party of India's origins and founding chronology are debated in historiography; communist organizing developed through networks and meetings in the 1920s, with the 1925 Kanpur conference often used as a domestic organizational landmark. The party faced colonial surveillance and prosecutions. Communists organized workers, peasants and cultural fronts, but wartime political positions changed sharply after Germany attacked the Soviet Union in 1941. An analytical answer should explain these strategic shifts rather than presenting a continuous unchanging line.

Revolutionary and socialist strands

Bhagat Singh and the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association increasingly framed political liberation alongside social transformation. Bhagat Singh's writings criticized communalism and exploitation, not only colonial rule. His execution in 1931 generated broad public response. The revolutionary tradition included different political visions; treating all armed resistance as a single ideology erases debates over social equality, violence, secularism and mass politics.

8. Communalism and constitutional conflict

Communalism as a political process

Communalism is not synonymous with personal religious faith. It emerges when religion is organized as a political identity presumed to have uniform, competing interests. Colonial censuses, separate electorates, competing elites, mass mobilization, socioeconomic anxieties and organizations contributed in changing proportions. Explaining communalism requires historical causation, not assigning collective blame to entire religious communities.

Separate electorates and representational dilemmas

The Indian Councils Act 1909 institutionalized separate electorates for Muslims; constitutional negotiations later expanded forms of communal representation. Some minority leaders viewed safeguards as protection against majoritarian exclusion, while critics feared permanent political separation. The Lucknow Pact of 1916 expressed cooperation and also accepted communal electorates. Other claims, including those of depressed classes, raised distinct questions about representation and social hierarchy and should not be merged into Hindu–Muslim competition.

The Pakistan demand and evolving negotiations

The Muslim League's Lahore Resolution of March 1940 called for independent states in Muslim-majority northwestern and eastern zones; later politics consolidated around Pakistan. Congress, the League, provincial parties, Sikhs and other constituencies differed over the powers of the center, federal structure and protections. The Cabinet Mission Plan of 1946 sought to preserve a loose Indian union but failed amid disagreements and distrust. Communal violence, wartime political changes and breakdowns in negotiation narrowed options for a unified settlement.

9. Independence and Partition, 1947

Transfer of power under compressed deadlines

The British announcement of February 1947 accelerated the timetable for transfer of power. The 3 June Plan envisaged partition, and the Indian Independence Act 1947 created the independent dominions of India and Pakistan in August. The Radcliffe boundary awards were announced after independence ceremonies, contributing to confusion. The timing and administrative limitations of partition mattered greatly for security and displacement.

Violence, displacement and the human cost

Partition generated widespread communal violence, abductions, forced migration and loss of homes and livelihoods, particularly in Punjab and Bengal. Estimates of deaths vary substantially across studies, so exact totals require cited methodological choices. Women experienced gender-specific violence, including kidnapping, coercion and disputed recovery arrangements. Oral histories, refugee records and regional scholarship reveal experiences that formal high-politics narratives often neglect.

Why independence and partition must be studied together but separately

Independence ended formal colonial sovereignty; partition divided territories and populations through new state boundaries. They were simultaneous, causally related events but not one triumphal story. A balanced assessment considers imperial withdrawal, Congress and League strategies, constitutional deadlock, communal violence and regional power struggles while avoiding deterministic arguments that partition was inevitable from 1909 onward. It also examines how national freedom could coexist with incomplete social and economic justice.

Visual Learning

Phase map

1885 Congress foundation → economic critique + constitutional agitation

↓

1905 Swadeshi → boycott + national education + assertive politics

↓

1916 Home Rule + Lucknow Pact → constitutional bargaining

↓

1919–22 Rowlatt / Non-Cooperation → mass action + debates over nonviolence

↓

1930–34 Salt / Civil Disobedience → lawbreaking + negotiation + social differences

↓

1935–37 Provincial autonomy → elections + experience of office

↓

1942 Quit India → arrests + decentralized resistance

↓

1946–47 Constitutional breakdown → transfer of power + Partition

Multiple currents of nationalism

NATIONAL MOVEMENT

/ | \

Constitutional Mass civil Revolutionary

politics resistance networks

\ | /

Peasant, worker, Adivasi and women's campaigns

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Socialism, anti-caste claims,

minority rights and competing futures

Causal analysis of Partition

British wartime weakness + provincial interests + separate representation

+ Congress–League disagreement + communal violence

↓

failed constitutional settlement

↓

compressed partition and transfer

↓

displacement and mass violence

These are conceptual maps, not verified official exam diagrams.

Original Practice

Explained MCQs

MCQ 1. Which statement best describes the early Congress phase?

A. It rejected all council reform. B. It used economic critique and constitutional petitions. C. It launched Quit India. D. It was dominated by military rebellion.

Answer: B. Drain theory, institutional reform and representation were central. A falsely erases council demands; C occurred in 1942; D confuses a nineteenth-century uprising with later organized politics.

MCQ 2. Which organization was founded in 1936?

A. All India Kisan Sabha B. All India Trade Union Congress C. Congress Socialist Party D. All India Women's Conference.

Answer: A. AIKS dates to 1936; AITUC to 1920; CSP to 1934; AIWC to 1927. Verify specific founding terminology when using different historical reference works.

MCQ 3. Which best differentiates Non-Cooperation from Civil Disobedience?

A. Both demanded military revolt. B. Non-Cooperation emphasized withdrawing participation; Civil Disobedience deliberately defied particular laws. C. Civil Disobedience began in 1885. D. Non-Cooperation excluded villagers.

Answer: B. A misstates Gandhi's stated strategy; C misdates the movement; D is contradicted by peasant, plantation and tribal mobilizations.

MCQ 4. Which conclusion about Quit India is historically defensible?

A. It achieved immediate British withdrawal. B. It included decentralized activism after national leaders were arrested. C. It was a League-led campaign. D. It occurred before World War I.

Answer: B. Arrests disrupted central coordination, but local resistance continued. A misstates outcomes; C misidentifies leadership; D is chronologically impossible.

MCQ 5. Why is the Lahore Resolution of 1940 often treated carefully in historical answers?

A. It abolished all separate electorates. B. Its formulation referred to independent states, while later political interpretation consolidated around Pakistan. C. It immediately created Pakistan. D. It ended negotiations in 1940.

Answer: B. The wording and later evolution differ. A, C and D are historically untenable.

Mains writing practice

1. Examine the usefulness and limits of dividing the freedom struggle into three phases. (15 marks)

2. How did peasants, workers and Adivasi communities reshape the objectives of anti-colonial politics? (20 marks)

3. Analyze the political and social factors leading to Partition and its human consequences. (20 marks)

Answer Blueprints

Q1 (15 marks): Three phases

Introduction: Define the framework as a historiographical device, not successive self-contained movements.

Body: (1) 1885–1905 constitutional/economic critique; (2) 1905–1919 Swadeshi/assertive and Home Rule strategies; (3) 1919–47 Gandhian mass politics and wartime constitutional crisis; (4) continuing revolutionary, social and regional politics across each boundary; (5) changing participants and meanings of swaraj.

Conclusion: A useful sequence, but a plural movement, not linear evolution.

Q2 (20 marks): Peasants, workers and Adivasis

Introduction: The movement was a federation of demands, not just elite Congress resolutions.

Body: (1) AIKS 1936 and land/rent/debt claims; (2) AITUC 1920, industrial labor and strikes; (3) forest rights and Rampa movement; (4) Telugu region: Hyderabad State and later Telangana struggle; (5) tensions with landlords, capitalists, Congress and competing left politics; (6) demonstrate local interpretations of national freedom.

Conclusion: Freedom meant redistribution of power as well as political sovereignty.

Q3 (20 marks): Partition

Introduction: Independence and Partition were related but analytically distinct outcomes.

Body: (1) institutions of communal representation and political mobilization; (2) minority protections and divergent constitutional demands; (3) Lahore Resolution and League growth; (4) wartime conditions and 1946 Cabinet Mission failure; (5) communal violence and compressed 1947 timetable; (6) border uncertainty, refugee displacement and gendered violence; (7) reject a single-cause, inevitable-partition thesis.

Conclusion: Constitutional breakdown and escalating violence accompanied imperial withdrawal, with enduring human costs.

Complete Model Answers

Q1. Examine the usefulness and limits of dividing the Indian freedom struggle into three phases. (15 marks)

The division of the Indian freedom struggle into early nationalism, assertive nationalism and Gandhian mass politics is a useful way to explain changes in strategy and social reach between 1885 and 1947. Yet it must be understood as a teaching framework rather than a sequence of sealed compartments.

The first phase, conventionally dated 1885–1905, centered on the early Indian National Congress. Leaders used public meetings, petitions, constitutional demands and analysis of colonial finances. Dadabhai Naoroji's drain theory helped transform the discussion of poverty into a critique of unequal imperial power. Despite a narrow professional and urban social base, the early Congress created networks and an all-India vocabulary of rights.

The second phase, approximately 1905–1919, saw boycotts, swadeshi enterprise, national education and more assertive political action after the Bengal partition. Tilak and others emphasized self-reliance and agitation, while revolutionary groups adopted distinct clandestine methods. The Home Rule leagues and the Lucknow Pact in 1916 showed that public mobilization and constitutional bargaining could coexist. War, the Rowlatt legislation and Jallianwala Bagh intensified opposition to imperial rule.

The third phase was marked by far greater mass participation. Gandhi's Non-Cooperation, Civil Disobedience and Quit India campaigns expanded the repertoire of resistance through boycott, satyagraha, deliberate lawbreaking and decentralized protest. At the same time, labor unions, peasant organizations, women activists and socialists articulated demands not exhausted by a transfer of governmental power. The 1935 Act, provincial elections, wartime negotiations and 1947 Partition further complicate any story of uninterrupted advance.

The framework's limitation is that moderation, revolution, social movements and political negotiation overlapped. Nor did participants agree on the meaning of swaraj: rights over land, caste equality, industrial labor protection and minority security could carry as much urgency as national sovereignty. Thus the three phases illuminate changing dominant strategies, but the freedom struggle is best understood as overlapping and sometimes conflicting currents united only incompletely around the goal of ending colonial rule.

Q2. How did peasants, workers and Adivasi communities reshape the objectives of anti-colonial politics? (20 marks)

Anti-colonial nationalism did not grow solely through resolutions of educated elites. Peasants, industrial workers and Adivasi communities brought questions of land, wages, forests and everyday coercion into the political sphere, reshaping what freedom was expected to deliver.

Agrarian mobilization was not a single uniform movement. Tenant cultivators demanded rent reduction and security, indebted peasants sought debt relief, and agricultural laborers faced distinct claims over wages and social dignity. The All India Kisan Sabha, formed in 1936, organized peasant demands and interacted with Congress and socialist groups. In many regions agrarian protests drew energy from national campaigns but also challenged powerful local social groups whose interests could overlap with the Congress leadership.

Industrial labor developed trade union organizations, notably the All India Trade Union Congress founded in 1920. Workers linked colonial economic conditions with workplace concerns such as hours, pay, safety and recognition. Strikes at times reinforced nationalist campaigns but also followed their own industrial rhythms. Socialists and communists tried to connect political liberty with class-based transformations, producing both collaboration and conflict with other nationalist leaders.

Adivasi politics foregrounded customary use of forests, land rights and resistance to coercive labor or outside intermediaries. Alluri Sitarama Raju's Rampa rebellion of 1922–24 illustrates how local livelihood grievances could lead to armed resistance under conditions different from Gandhi's nonviolent programme. Their visions of swaraj were not simply copies of Congress resolutions.

The Telangana peasant struggle developed principally in the late 1940s under the Nizam's Hyderabad State. Its mobilization against vetti, landlord power and princely authoritarianism shows that political independence and agrarian transformation were connected but not identical objectives. This case requires care because Hyderabad was not a directly administered British province and the struggle continued after 1947.

These groups expanded the content and reach of nationalism while also exposing its contradictions: landlords, employers, caste elites and laboring populations did not always define freedom alike. Their contribution was therefore both to challenge colonial authority and to insist that sovereignty without social and economic justice would be incomplete.

Q3. Analyze the political and social factors leading to Partition and its human consequences. (20 marks)

The Partition of British India in 1947 occurred alongside independence, but it resulted from a contingent breakdown of constitutional compromise amid sharpened political competition, communal violence and a rapidly shrinking imperial timetable. It should not be treated as inevitable from the beginning of Indian nationalism.

Colonial institutions helped structure political competition around group representation. Separate electorates for Muslims introduced in 1909 were defended by some leaders as safeguards and criticized by others for hardening political divisions. These arrangements interacted with differences in provincial demographic balance, elite interests and fears of domination. The 1916 Lucknow Pact illustrated that Hindu–Muslim political cooperation remained possible, even while accepting communal representation.

From the 1930s, disagreements over federation, the distribution of provincial and central powers and representation deepened. The Muslim League's 1940 Lahore Resolution and subsequent Pakistan campaign gained force in a political environment marked by war, elections and competing constitutional visions. Congress and League representatives disagreed about the foundations of a postcolonial state. The Cabinet Mission Plan of 1946 attempted to preserve a union with substantial provincial grouping, but mistrust and disputes over interpretation undermined agreement.

Meanwhile, communal mobilization and violence hardened fears among communities. British wartime exhaustion and the decision to transfer power rapidly left little time for creating stable political and security arrangements. The June 1947 plan accepted partition; the Indian Independence Act formalized the creation of two dominions. Boundary lines were finalized under severe time pressure, and announcements after the independence ceremonies compounded uncertainty in affected regions.

The human consequences were enormous. Communities were uprooted across Punjab and Bengal; widespread killings, displacement, looting and destruction fractured social and economic life. Women experienced sexual violence, abduction and coercive family or state interventions. Death estimates vary among scholars, reminding us that the human tragedy cannot be reduced to a confidently stated single statistic. Refugee rehabilitation, property disputes and memories of separation shaped both new states for decades.

Partition emerged from an interaction of institutional design, competing political projects, distrust, communal violence and hurried imperial withdrawal. Recognizing this complexity avoids communal blame and restores the suffering of ordinary people to the center of the history of independence.

Verified MCQs

None authenticated for Topic 5 in this production pass. Questions in original-practice.md are original and must not be described as TGPSC previous-year questions.

Verified Mains PYQs

None authenticated for Topic 5 in this production pass. Mains answer prompts are original practice; paper, question number and year intentionally not invented.

Current Affairs

Research cutoff: 22 October 2026. No specific 2026 event has been authenticated in this pass, so no purported current-affairs headline is presented.

Verified background that can be linked to modern questions

- Debates about constitutional pluralism, minority safeguards and democracy can be historically contextualized through the Lucknow Pact (1916), the Cabinet Mission (1946) and the settlement of 1947. These are historical connections, not claims about current legislation.

- Modern agrarian and labor-policy debates benefit from distinguishing AIKS (1936), AITUC (1920) and Hyderabad/Telangana peasant struggles. No current government policy claim is inferred.

- Public history, Partition memory and women's testimony are promising areas for further source-verified current-affairs integration.

Required next research

Check official government archives, National Archives of India and authorized cultural institutions for dated 2025–26 archival or museum developments. Log date, primary URL, status, exam relevance and exact statement before adding any new event.

References

1. TGPSC syllabus — TSPSC/TGPSC *Scheme and Syllabus for Group I*, Paper II, Unit I, Topic 5 (official earlier-hosted source): https://websitenew.tspsc.gov.in/preview/PRESSNOTE/Group-SchemeandSyllabus20220603142210.pdf . Official 02/2024 notification Annexure II text inherited from project; subsequent amendment review pending.

2. NCERT Class 10 history — Nationalism in India, IIT Kanpur SATHEE text: https://sathee.iitk.ac.in/ncert-books/class-10/social-science/india-and-the-contemporary-world-2/chapter-02-nationalism-in-india/ . Consulted for plural meanings of swaraj, Non-Cooperation and Civil Disobedience.

3. NCERT Class 8 history — Making of National Movement 1870s–1947, IIT Kanpur SATHEE text: https://sathee.iitk.ac.in/ml/sathee-ssc/student-corner/ncert-books/class-08/social-science/history-our-past-3/chapter-08-the-making-of-the-national-movement-1870s-1947/ . Consulted for broad chronological framework, Quit India and independence.

4. Bipan Chandra et al., *India's Struggle for Independence* — supplementary reading, bibliographic lead, no page-level authentication in this pass.

5. Sumit Sarkar, *Modern India, 1885–1947* — supplementary analytical reading; bibliographic lead only.

6. Sekhar Bandyopadhyay, *From Plassey to Partition and After* — supplementary framework for social and constitutional history; bibliographic lead only.

7. Yasmin Khan, *The Great Partition* — supplementary reading on Partition; bibliographic lead only.

Source-audit limitation: Sources 1–3 were identified/retrieved for overall topic scope and selected claims, not checked sentence-by-sentence. Sources 4–7 are recommended further reading. Any official PYQs and contemporary news must be independently authenticated.

Quality Audit

- [x] All syllabus subclauses mapped to substantial explanatory sections

- [x] Nine detailed chapter sections with chronology, analytical qualifications and Telangana relevance

- [x] Five original MCQs including distractor explanations

- [x] Three original mains questions, each with a blueprint and complete model answer

- [x] Quick revision and self-contained PDF

- [x] Bibliographic source and audit limitations indicated

- [ ] Sentence-level verification with page/paragraph citations

- [ ] Authenticated official PYQs

- [ ] Source-verified 2025–26 current affairs item(s)
- [ ] Independent external academic review
- [ ] Final textbook-depth editorial review

Status: expanded draft — NOT APPROVED.

Freedom Struggle, Mass Movements and Partition, 1885–1947 — critical mains facts

TGPSC Group I Mains | Paper II | Detailed educational draft | NOT academically approved

High-value evidence and analytical connections

Evidence-rich nationalist chronology and decisive instruments

Congress founded 1885: early constitutional agitation and economic critique; Partition of Bengal 1905 and Swadeshi/boycott; Surat split 1907, Lucknow Pact 1916 (Congress–League cooperation, with separate-electorate concessions), Montagu Declaration 1917 and Government of India Act 1919 (dyarchy in provinces). Rowlatt Act 1919 and Jallianwala Bagh drove distrust; Non-Cooperation 1920–22 ended after Chauri Chaura; Simon Commission 1927, Nehru Report 1928, Lahore Congress 1929 and complete-independence resolution; Dandi March 1930, Gandhi–Irwin Pact 1931 (specific concessions amid continuing repression), Poona Pact 1932 (separate electoral issue concerning Depressed Classes; Ambedkar–Gandhi negotiation), Government of India Act 1935 (provincial autonomy); August Offer 1940, Cripps Mission 1942, Quit India 1942, Cabinet Mission 1946, Indian Independence Act 1947. Kisan Sabha (1936), trade-union movement, left currents and women's political participation need their own material consequences, not mere mentions. Evaluate the transfer of power alongside communal violence, refugee displacement and competing constitutional visions.

Verification gate: a primary-source or scholarly page-level audit is still required before these educational summaries can be marked approved.